

Can AI forge better cricketers?

Str8bat co-founder **Gagan Daga** thinks so

Bhaskar Sharma | editor@digit.in

As they say, cricket is more than a sport in India. The game is an emotion and is literally worshipped across the nation. While the professional teams use technology and data at a big stage, the grassroots players often depend only on experience and limited feedback. This is where Str8bat comes into play, aiming to fill that gap between performance and understanding.

Str8bat uses technology that uses sensors, software and artificial intelligence to explain player performance, helping batters and coaches understand strengths, mistakes, and areas for improvement. The company's small sticker-like device attaches to a cricket bat and captures detailed movement data, giving players insights into aspects of their game that are otherwise difficult to track consistently.

During a recent interaction with Digit, Str8bat co-founder Gagan Daga shared his insights and journey.

Looking beyond the scoreboard

The problem with traditional sports analysis is not the lack of statistics, says the co-founder Gagan Daga. He said that it's the type of statistics that are commonly used. Cricket,

like many sports, is largely judged through outcomes, which include runs, wickets, catches and strike rates. However, Daga believes that these are all retrospective measurements, as they explain what happened after the fact rather than providing clues about future performance.

'Sports are completely measured by what has happened. There are no leading indicators that describe the game and help you perform better consistently,' Daga explained during the conversation.

When a player is struggling, the first thing that a coach or analyst does is review game footage

and practice sessions and assess what the problem is. While this method may work, it depends a lot on analysis. Objective motion measurements could be yet another way to gain insight.

According to Daga, metrics like bat speed, impact speed, bat path, timing, balance and consistency of sweet spot contact can give clues about trends in an athlete's performance before they become apparent in game statistics. In his opinion, such metrics are similar to leading indicators used in economics and finance. They give advance notice to allow athletes to make adjustments to their performance before it worsens significantly.



Gagan Daga
Co-founder, Str8bat

The idea behind Str8bat

The origins of Str8bat go back to 2017, when the company set out to create a product capable of measuring batting performance in a simple and accessible way. Instead of relying on costly cameras or special infrastructure, the researchers wanted to develop something that would blend seamlessly into a batsman's natural play pattern. This led to the development of a small



sensor that is attached to the cricket bat itself. Despite its small size, the device captures a significant amount of movement information every time a player trains or plays. The sensor activates through motion, records data during use and automatically enters sleep mode when left idle to conserve battery life.

At first glance, the hardware appears remarkably simple as it comes with a form factor that does not interfere with batting technique or require players to change the way they train. Summarising the philosophy that has guided the product's development, Daga said, 'What you cannot measure, you cannot improve.' He further added that the aim is not merely to collect numbers but to provide meaningful feedback that players can act upon, and by turning bat movement into measurable data, Str8bat seeks to make the invisible parts of batting visible like never before. **d**

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